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From Campus to Clean Energy: How CESR's Experiential Learning Launched a Career in Energy Policy

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Hyde Weissenfluh (Entrepreneurship, SRE'22) is a lifelong environmentalist. His childhood interest in sustainability stemmed from his parents' values and the natural beauty of Colorado, his home state. Now he supports federal clean energy investments and state-level policies at Colorado's largest energy provider, Xcel Energy.

Hyde recently spoke to CESR about his story, crediting the [Social Responsibility and Ethics \(SRE\) Degree Certificate](#)'s experiential learning opportunities for launching his career.

In his capstone project for this undergrad certificate, Hyde reviewed Xcel Energy's sustainability reporting and presented recommendations for the company to strengthen their environmental initiatives. Impressed with his work, they offered Hyde a summer internship to implement the recommendations that he and his team created. After the internship, they then hired him as an energy and technology policy analyst. Hyde's journey from a conservation-minded Colorado kid to working with clean energy startups proves

how showing up determined can create meaningful impact.

Shaping the Future in an Evolving Industry

Hyde remembers being an environmentalist long before he stepped into a classroom. "I've always been very interested in sustainability," he started, "though I will say I was more focused on conservation when I was younger." He knew he wanted to make a difference in his career, but had no specific vision when he entered Leeds.

Our conversation meandered from the latest policy developments to broader industry trends. Multiple times, Hyde emphasized what he thinks to be the most important aspect of sustainability education: agility. "Sustainability" moves fast; policies and markets might change dramatically within the four years someone takes to earn their degree. Hyde appreciated how even in his first CESR course, he felt the class "adapting to real-time changes and news in the ESG space." While analyzing the forces behind the sustainability movement and learning how to adapt, classes "built upon each other," making the skills he learned more meaningful.

"My favorite part is using the publicly available climate scenarios we learned at Leeds to build climate analyses from the ground up."

For instance, his SRE capstone course introduced him to Climate Scenario Analysis (CSA) and the Task Force on Climate-related Financial Disclosures (TCFD) reporting. He said the frameworks were exciting and eye-opening; these weren't just abstract concepts, but tools spurring real corporate responsibility. Hyde was especially drawn to the rigor and depth of climate scenario analysis, which is now a big part of his job.

Beyond knowledge and newfound passion, the SRE Certificate's experiential learning requirements gave Hyde direct industry experience and a strong business network. He says "the experience of getting to work with companies in two separate SRE classes" made the biggest difference for him.

In his capstone project, Hyde and his classmates partnered with Xcel Energy to review the company's sustainability reporting and offer

strategic recommendations aligned with TCFD guidelines. Hyde took this networking opportunity seriously, and Xcel took their recommendations seriously. The company quickly hired him as an intern to implement his group's suggestions, and when the internship ended in 2022, Hyde accepted a full-time offer as an energy and technology policy analyst.

Supporting Clean Energy Innovations Across Colorado

Now, Hyde plays a key role in advancing clean energy projects at Xcel Energy. His work focuses on securing federal funding for innovative energy initiatives and startups, including the Heartland Hydrogen Hub, Form Energy's multi-day energy storage projects, and the Prime Time Virtual Power Plant program.

"Getting to see these first-of-their-kind clean energy projects through conceptual planning, funding and applications, and now seeing them being built is great," Hyde shared. He says his entrepreneurship major combined with the SRE Certificate gives him the right mindset to work effectively with emerging carbon-free technology startups, ultimately finding them funding.

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What's more, the skills Hyde gained in his CESR coursework now inform Xcel Energy's clean energy mix and long-term strategy. "My favorite part is using the publicly available climate scenarios we learned at Leeds to build climate analyses from the ground up. Looking at different pathways to 1.5°C and 2.0°C and how the company's strategy lines up with those."

Hyde's work feels especially meaningful because of its direct impact on his home state. "Being from Colorado, it's exciting to work on projects and policies that will shape our local energy mix and support the state's clean energy goals." His efforts drive Xcel Energy's commitment to becoming a net-zero energy provider by 2050.

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To our Colorado business community, thank you for supporting CESR students! And Hyde, congratulations. We need more changemakers like you. And if you're a Leeds undergraduate who read this far down, we're so proud of you. [Email us](#) to learn more about CESR's SRE Certificate, and join [Sustainable Business Club](#) to get involved in our many on-campus events.

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